

"Covid is picking up immune escape mutations the most as it allows it to continue to spread amongst populations"

— DR SHAHID JAMEEL
Director, Trivedi School of Biosciences, Ashoka University



"You could argue that the pandemic phase has been over for about six months in India. We have not seen any major hospitalisations or surges"

— DR GAGANDEEP KANG
Professor, CMC Vellore



"We are currently in a relatively comfortable, happy position in the country as far as Covid is concerned"

— DR N.K. ARORA
Chairman, National Covid-19 Task Force

of the 1918 Spanish Flu virus still circulate amidst us, causing regular flu, even if the flu vaccine affords some protection against it. However, while continuing to be infectious, flu is not deadly for most hosts.

This is unlike other viruses such as Ebola, or SARS. When it was raging in 2014-16, Ebola had an average case fatality rate (CFR) of 50 per cent, and SARS 11 per cent in 2003. Both these viruses were not as infectious or long-lasting like Covid is proving to be because they were too deadly. (A current Ebola upsurge in Uganda is causing some concern though, especially as a vaccine against the Sudan strain causing the current outbreak is still in the works.) If its host dies, a virus is unable to transmit further. The coronavirus, on the other hand, is racing to stay one up on immune antibody responses to be able to re-infect and prolong its existence.

RISING CASES BUT LOWER DEATHS INDICATE THAT THE VIRUS MAY BE BECOMING MORE INFECTIOUS BUT NOT DEADLIER

However, even if the Covid-19 virus is running out of possibilities for a major evolutionary jump, it is difficult to say if there will be none. Dr Mishra, who continues to wear masks in public, says, "Usually, one set of mutations make a virus more infectious and another more symptomatic. It is quite rare for both to happen together; we would be unlucky if that did happen." The world can thus drop its masks but not its guard against the virus just yet.

ETERNAL VIGILANCE

While Covid has taken much away from us, it has also left us with a lot to learn. "One day, we will be able to look back and see the benefits After Covid (AC) and Before Covid (BC)," says Dr Devi Shetty, chairman of Narayana Health. "The accessibility, affordability and awareness on health due to the pandemic has hugely improved." From just one laboratory for testing in March 2020, India today has more than 4,000 facilities, equipped to screen and run RT-PCR tests for the disease. In addition, over 56 labs are now part of INSACOG or the Indian SARS-CoV-2 Consortium on Genomics, the